Tamil Nadu Assembly Elections
2001 – 2021

A Comprehensive Exploratory Data Analysis

Five Elections | 234 Constituencies | 25 Years of Political Patterns

5	234	4/5	57%
Elections Analyzed	Constituencies	Anti-Incumbency Rate	Avg Seat Flip Rate

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1. Overview & Macro-Level Trends

1.1 Electoral Participation

Tamil Nadu has seen a dramatic rise in voter participation over the 25-year period. Registered electors grew from 47.5 million in 2001 to nearly 60 million in 2021 — a 26% expansion of the electorate. More strikingly, the number of votes cast nearly doubled from 28 million to 45.9 million, driven both by electorate growth and improving turnout.

Year	Registered Electors	Votes Cast	Voter Turnout	Winner
2001	4,74,79,000	2,80,48,077	59.1%	AIADMK
2006	4,66,61,754	3,30,45,949	70.8%	DMK
2011	4,71,16,336	3,68,42,687	78.2%	AIADMK
2016	5,74,50,805	4,26,46,591	74.2%	AIADMK
2021	5,99,36,039	4,58,86,784	76.6%	DMK

Note: The sharp jump in registered electors between 2011 and 2016 reflects major electoral roll revision cycles.

1.2 Seat Tally — The Duopoly in Numbers

Tamil Nadu politics is structurally a two-bloc system. DMK and AIADMK together accounted for 90%+ of assembly seats in every election this century. No third party has come close to breaking this dominance over a sustained period.

Year	DMK	AIADMK	INC	DMDK	PMK	BJP	Others
2001	31	**132**	7	—	20	4	40
2006	**96**	61	34	1	18	—	24
2011	23	**150**	5	29	3	—	24
2016	89	**134**	8	—	—	—	1
2021	**133**	66	18	—	5	4	8

2. The Anti-Incumbency Phenomenon

The single most defining feature of Tamil Nadu's electoral history is near-perfect anti-incumbency. With one notable exception (2016), every government since 1967 has been voted out after a single term. This makes Tamil Nadu arguably the most anti-incumbency-prone large state in India.

Key Finding

The ruling party has been voted out in 4 of the 5 elections this century. The average outgoing party lost over 80 seats. When Tamil Nadu voters turn, they turn completely.

2.1 The Record of Incumbents

Year	Outgoing Ruler	Seats Retained	New Winner	Winner's Seats	Verdict
2001	**DMK**	31 (from 168)	**AIADMK**	132	**Swept out**
2006	**AIADMK**	61 (from 132)	**DMK**	96	**Swept out**
2011	**DMK**	23 (from 96)	**AIADMK**	150	**Swept out**
2016	**AIADMK**	134 (retained)	**AIADMK**	134	**Rare retention**
2021	**AIADMK**	66 (from 134)	**DMK**	133	**Swept out**

2.2 Swing Magnitude

TN elections are not close contests — they are tidal waves. The average seat swing between elections exceeds 60 seats per party. The 2011 election saw the most dramatic swing, with AIADMK gaining 89 seats and DMK losing 73 in a single election.

Period	DMK Seat Change	AIADMK Seat Change	Context
2001→2006	**+65 (31→96)**	−71 (132→61)	2G-era goodwill, strong DMK alliance
2006→2011	−73 (96→23)	**+89 (61→150)**	2G scandal, DMDK split DMK votes
2011→2016	**+66 (23→89)**	−16 (150→134)	AIADMK retained; Jayalalithaa factor
2016→2021	**+44 (89→133)**	−68 (134→66)	Post-Jayalalithaa leadership vacuum

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2.3 The 2016 Exception — Why Did AIADMK Retain Power?

The 2016 election is the only instance of incumbent retention in TN's modern history. Several factors explain this anomaly:

- Jayalalithaa's personal popularity overrode structural anti-incumbency — the only election fought around a personality rather than governance.
- DMDK, the main spoiler party of 2011 that cost DMK bloc votes, contested alone in 2016 and won zero seats, failing to split votes meaningfully.
- The DMK's seat total recovered to 89 — a normal opposition gain — but not enough to unseat a strong AIADMK alliance.
- Notably, AIADMK still lost 16 seats from 2011's landslide of 150. The 'retention' was real but significantly diminished.

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3. Competitiveness & Margin Analysis

3.1 Winning Margins Over Time

Winning margins are not stable — they spike in landslide years and compress in competitive elections. The 2011 and 2021 elections saw the highest average margins (both around 22,800 votes), correlating with the winners' dominant seat tallies.

Year	Avg Margin	Median Margin	Seats < 5k votes	Seats > 30k votes	Landslides > 50k
2001	15,511	13,760	46 (20%)	24 (10%)	0
2006	10,405	8,578	72 (31%)	9 (4%)	0
2011	**22,654**	21,432	25 (11%)	60 (26%)	**13**
2016	14,937	12,691	53 (23%)	27 (12%)	4
2021	**22,866**	19,895	39 (17%)	62 (26%)	**25**

3.2 Razor-Thin Contests

Despite the macro-level dominance of one party per election, a significant number of constituencies are decided by very slim margins. In 2006, 13 seats were won by fewer than 500 votes. The most extreme: Singanallur (2006) was won by just 14 votes.

Year	Closest Constituency	Second Closest	Margin (votes)	Winner Party
2001	Cuddalore	Egmore	**34 / 86**	DMK / DMK
2006	Singanallur	Madurai East	**14 / 51**	AIADMK / CPM
2011	Egmore	Chengalpattu	**202 / 291**	DMDK / DMDK
2016	Radhapuram	Kattumannarkoil	**49 / 87**	AIADMK / AIADMK
2021	Thiyagarayanagar	Modakkurichi	**137 / 281**	DMK / BJP

3.3 Winner Vote Share — A Tale of Fragmentation

One of the most striking findings in this dataset is how low winner vote shares are across the board. The average winning candidate received just 7.8–14.3% of the total electorate. No winner across all five elections crossed 50% of total electors. This is a direct consequence of low-to-medium turnout combined with multi-party contests splitting the vote.

Key Finding

In 2021, only 2 out of 234 winners crossed 50% of votes cast. In 2006, not a single winner did. TN elections are overwhelmingly won on plurality — the winner needs only to be the least-disliked option in a crowded field.

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4. Geographic Fault Lines

Tamil Nadu's political geography is not uniform. Analysis of district-level results reveals clear regional identities that persist across elections, pointing to structural socioeconomic and caste factors that transcend any single election cycle.

4.1 The Kongu Belt — AIADMK's Last Fortress

The western districts of Coimbatore, Salem, Erode, and Dharmapuri form what is widely called the Kongu Belt. This region is home to dominant OBC communities (especially Gounder) who have historically aligned with AIADMK. The data confirms this:

District	AIADMK 2011	AIADMK 2016	AIADMK 2021	Trend
Coimbatore (16 seats)	**81%**	**88%**	**88%**	Unshakeable AIADMK bastion
Salem (11 seats)	73%	**91%**	73%	Strong hold, slight dip in 2021
Dharmapuri (5 seats)	40%	60%	60%	PMK influence dilutes AIADMK
Erode (10 seats)	**80%**	**90%**	40%	Significant DMK inroads in 2021

Coimbatore is the outlier of all outliers — it voted 88% AIADMK even in 2021 when AIADMK won only 66 seats statewide. This regional loyalty is structural, not responsive to statewide waves.

4.2 The DMK Heartland — North and the Cauvery Delta

DMK's strongest geographic clusters in 2021 were in the northern districts and the Cauvery delta, where the party swept comprehensively:

District	DMK 2011	DMK 2016	DMK 2021	Trend
Tiruchirappalli (10 seats)	10%	50%	**100%**	Total DMK sweep in 2021
Chennai (16 seats)	12%	62%	**94%**	Near-total dominance in 2021
Thiruvallur (10 seats)	0%	30%	**90%**	Dramatic reversal over 10 years
Thanjavur (8 seats)	25%	57%	**88%**	Delta belt swings heavily DMK

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Karur (3 seats)	33%	0%	**100%**	Complete reversal in 2021

4.3 Most Volatile Districts

Some districts flip almost entirely between elections, acting as bellwether regions that amplify statewide swings. The 2016→2021 period saw the following districts flip over 75% of their seats:

- Karur and Perambalur — 100% flip rate (all seats changed hands)
- Ramanathapuram — 100% flip rate, now a DMK stronghold
- Krishnagiri and Namakkal — 83% flip rate
- Nagapattinam — 83% flip rate

In contrast, Salem (18%) and Pudukkottai (20%) showed the greatest resistance to the 2021 DMK wave, with AIADMK holding most of its seats.

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5. Constituency-Level Loyalty Analysis

5.1 The Loyalty Spectrum

Across 234 constituencies tracked over 5 elections, the distribution of political loyalty reveals that TN has very few truly 'safe' seats. Only 13 constituencies voted for the same party in all five elections studied. The majority sit in the middle ground — loyal enough to provide a party's floor, but flippable under the right conditions.

Loyalty Score	No. of Constituencies	% of Total	Interpretation
5/5 — Never flipped	13	5.6%	True fortress seats
4/5 — One flip	30	12.8%	Highly loyal, rare exception
3/5	98	41.9%	Leans one way but switches under pressure
2/5	61	26.1%	Genuinely contested battleground
1/5 — Almost always flips	15	6.4%	Reflects national/statewide wave entirely

5.2 Unbreakable Fortresses — Never Flipped in 25 Years

Only 13 constituencies voted for the same party in all five elections. Notably, AIADMK has more fortress seats (9) than DMK (4), yet still lost decisively in 2021. This reveals that AIADMK's loyalty base is geographically concentrated, while DMK's broader appeal was more evenly distributed across the state in 2021.

Constituency	Party	Region	Significance
Katpadi	**DMK**	Vellore	Northern plains DMK heartland
Tiruvannamalai	**DMK**	Tiruvannamalai	Strong caste consolidation for DMK
Oddanchatram	**DMK**	Dindigul	Also holds highest 2016 margin (65k+)
Kumbakonam	**DMK**	Thanjavur	Cauvery delta DMK anchor
Avanashi / Pollachi / Palladam	**AIADMK**	Coimbatore	Core Kongu Belt seats — rock solid
Perundurai / Gobichettipalayam	**AIADMK**	Erode	AIADMK holds even as Erode district shifts

Madurai West / Melur	**AIADMK**	Madurai	Urban-rural Madurai contrast
Vanur / Palacode	**AIADMK**	Villupuram / Dharmapuri	Pockets of AIADMK loyalty in DMK territory

5.3 The Most Volatile Battleground Seats

At the opposite extreme, 13 constituencies have flipped their winner in 4 out of 5 elections — changing every election except one. These seats are the true decision-makers in any election.

Constituency	2001	2006	2011	2016	2021	Flips
Tiruttani	PMK	AIADMK	DMDK	AIADMK	DMK	**4**
Krishnagiri	AIADMK	DMK	AIADMK	DMK	AIADMK	**4**
Kanniyakumari	AIADMK	DMK	AIADMK	DMK	AIADMK	**4**
Alangulam	AIADMK	DMK	AIADMK	DMK	AIADMK	**4**
Tirunelveli	AIADMK	DMK	AIADMK	DMK	BJP	**4**
Ramanathapuram	AIADMK	INC	MMK	AIADMK	DMK	**4**
Cumbum	TMC	MDMK	DMK	AIADMK	DMK	**4**

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6. Reserved Constituency Analysis

Tamil Nadu has 44 SC-reserved constituencies and 2 ST-reserved constituencies out of 234 total seats. Patterns in these seats offer insight into how the Dalit and tribal vote behaves relative to the general electorate.

6.1 SC Seat Turnout — Higher Than General

A consistent and often overlooked pattern: SC-reserved constituencies show higher average voter turnout than general constituencies. In 2021, SC seats averaged 79.0% turnout vs 76.5% in GEN seats. This gap has been consistent across multiple election cycles and suggests a highly mobilised Dalit electorate.

6.2 DMK Underperforms in SC Seats

Counterintuitively, DMK has historically won a smaller share of SC seats than GEN seats despite its left-leaning, Periyar heritage. The data shows a consistent pattern:

Year	DMK Win Rate (GEN)	DMK Win Rate (SC)	Gap
2001	14.3%	9.5%	−4.8 pts (underperforms in SC)
2006	39.7%	42.9%	+3.2 pts (outperforms)
2011	11.2%	4.5%	−6.7 pts (significant underperformance)
2016	40.9%	29.5%	**−11.4 pts (largest underperformance)**
2021	**59.0%**	47.7%	−11.3 pts (persists in DMK landslide year)

Key Finding

Even in 2021, when DMK won 133 seats in a landslide, it won only 47.7% of SC seats vs 59.0% of GEN seats. AIADMK holds a structural advantage in SC constituencies. This could reflect caste alliance politics, local leadership, or welfare scheme loyalty that cuts across bloc lines.

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7. Third Parties — Rise, Fall, and Alliance Value

Tamil Nadu has seen several third parties emerge, peak, and collapse within the span of one or two elections. None have sustained cross-electoral relevance as independent forces — they inevitably gravitate into one of the two blocs as alliance partners.

7.1 The Life Cycle of Third Parties

Party	2001	2006	2011	2016	2021	Trajectory
TMC (Moopanar)	**23**	0	0	0	0	One-election wonder; merged into INC
DMDK	0	1	**29**	0	0	Peaked 2011 on Vijayakanth; destroyed AIADMK
PMK	**20**	18	3	0	5	Caste party; fluctuates with alliances
INC	7	**34**	5	8	18	DMK alliance partner; never independent
BJP	4	0	0	0	4	Marginal presence; testing Tamil identity space
VCK	0	2	0	0	**4**	Portrayed as party for marginalized community; growing with DMK alliance

7.2 The DMDK Effect — 2011's Critical Spoiler

DMDK's 29-seat haul in 2011 is one of the most consequential third-party performances in TN history. The party drew votes almost entirely from DMK's traditional base, helping AIADMK win its historic 150-seat landslide. DMDK's complete collapse in 2016 (0 seats) after contesting solo confirms it had no durable support of its own — only protest votes.

7.3 Alliance Bloc Analysis

Looking beyond individual parties to the DMK-bloc vs AIADMK-bloc (which includes their respective allies), the picture becomes clearer:

Year	DMK Bloc Seats	AIADMK Bloc Seats	Others	Winning Bloc
2001	50	**177**	7	**AIADMK Bloc**
2006	**153**	80	1	**DMK Bloc**
2011	52	**182**	0	**AIADMK Bloc**

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2016	98	**134**	0	**AIADMK Bloc**
2021	**159**	71	4	**DMK Bloc**

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9. Summary of Key Findings

1. Anti-incumbency is the dominant force in TN politics — ruling parties have been voted out in 4 of 5 elections this century, with average swings exceeding 65 seats per party.
2. Tamil Nadu is a bipolar system. DMK and AIADMK blocs together won 95–100% of seats in every election. No third party has sustained relevance across two consecutive elections independently.
3. Geographic polarisation is deep and durable. The Kongu Belt (Coimbatore, Salem) is an AIADMK fortress; the northern belt and Cauvery delta (Chennai, Thiruvallur, Tiruchirappalli) are DMK heartlands.
4. Only 13 of 234 constituencies have never flipped in 25 years. AIADMK has more fortress seats (9) but loses them in wave elections. The median constituency has moderate loyalty and is winnable by either bloc.
5. SC-reserved constituencies consistently show higher turnout than GEN seats, yet DMK systematically underperforms in them — even in its 2021 landslide. AIADMK holds a structural advantage in reserved seats.
6. Winning margins correlate with the scale of victory: 2011 and 2021 (dominant wins) saw 25 and 13 seats won by >50k votes respectively. In more competitive elections (2006, 2016), the median margin almost halved.
7. No winner in any of the 5 elections ever crossed 50% of registered electors. TN elections are won on plurality in a fragmented field. Voter mobilisation and alliance coordination matter as much as popularity.

End of Report — Tamil Nadu Assembly Elections EDA 2001–2021

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